



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 49

WISCONSIN

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Wisconsin's family courts and child-welfare system.

36

WISCONSIN FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
51 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 8 MONTHS
MEDIAN TIME IN SYSTEM

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 24, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
10 OF 72

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

WISCONSIN AT A GLANCE.

Across 36 Wisconsin families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 51 36 of 36 families reporting with kids	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$75 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 8 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 41.7% 27.8% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 36	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.4	REPORTING FAMILIES 36 of 36	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 10

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Wisconsin families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF WISCONSIN FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	36	\$75	\$18,562	\$668,250
Lost Wages	36	\$300	\$20,878	\$751,600
Other Court Fees	36	\$0	\$4,280	\$154,068
Therapy / Evaluations	36	\$0	\$5,090	\$183,250
Reunification Services	36	\$0	\$958	\$34,500
GAL Fees	36	\$0	\$5,678	\$204,400
Asset Loss ¹	36	\$0	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$375	—	—

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$0) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		8	0.7 yrs
Mean months lost		20	1.7 yrs
Total across all families		705	58.8 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · WISCONSIN

Most families documenting in Wisconsin are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Unknown		15	42%
Currently involved / "S...		14	39%
I am currently stuck in...		3	8%
Case closed (more tha...		2	6%
Case closed (within th...		2	6%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and ...		14	39%
Family Court Only		11	31%
Unknown		6	17%
CPS (Child Protective ...		5	14%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		11	31%
5 – 10 years		6	17%
3 – 5 years		5	14%
6 months – 1 year		3	8%
Over 10 years		3	8%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		12	33%
No Contact / Total Los...		10	28%
Children in Foster Care		4	11%
50/50 Joint		4	11%
Full Custody		3	8%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Unknown		15	42%
Dane		2	6%
Fond du lac		2	6%
Waushara		2	6%
Lafayette-Grant County		1	3%
ST. CROIX		1	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Ac...		9	25%
Other: (Short answer)		6	17%
False Accusations CPS...		6	17%
Child Protective Servic...		3	8%
High Conflict Divorce		2	6%

05 PARENT VOICES — WISCONSIN

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Emotionally and mentally harmed my child and I. Stripped away our constitutional rights and our relationship.

— AMBER

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

The system to protect my family, ripped us apart, chewed us up, charged me to earn my rights back to even talk to my son-at the cost of our family home. We were never provided a fair trial or any legal steps to make this make sense. No due process, did not allow the "experts" [...]

— WISCONSIN PARENT · DANIELLE

MORE VOICES FROM WISCONSIN

Failed my children and I. We cannot count on any protection in the hands of the system. The system is the Devil. Lost trust within the system. They have traumatized us beyond the trauma we already had with the family abuse.

— CRYSTAL

Taken my civil rights to parent and be in my children's daily life. Ignored the true abuse to the children, by allowing convercive control through parent alienation of a targeted parent.

— JOY

Lengthened the process, falsely accused me the mom and victim of domestic violence of parents allenation, kids are terrified, kids have NO voice, daughter Noe has mental health issues and diagnosis of OCD and is begging for her voice to be heard in court. I am losing my home [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my family and traumatized 2 toddler girls in a way I experienced as a kid and NEVER wanted them to suffer.

— ALYSSA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I was made to pay to give my children away to my abuser including my daughter who is not biologically his. I was threatened with 6 months of jail time if I didn't pay GAL fees all while still having no access to my children and trying to rebuild my life.

— CHANDI

The system came into our lives and destroyed everything with a wrecking ball. My child has suffered extensive abuse and trauma, and now suffers from PTSD.

— MICHELLE

Deny evidence and silence our voices and put us right back in harm and trauma doing nothing but manipulating and gaslighting us. My lawyer took my money and turned my case around on me like I was the problem.

— CHRISTINE

My daughter was ripped away from me and I have been forced to relive the traumas of the past over and over. They have cause great harm in my daughters development.

— CORTNEE

After years of (well documented) domestic abuse and coercive control, my abuser has been rewarded for the harm he caused. I have no home, no transportation, no stability whatsoever, a lien on any future income, tens of thousands of dollars in debt, and severe chronic PTSD. I've [...]

— KIRA

The system has destroyed my family.

— ROBERT

It has given both my daughter and I trauma. We no longer trust anyone to actually help us who is supposed to help.

— DAWN

In my experience the system frowns upon any type of abuse besides directly physical being brought up, does not give victims the right to speak, and it brings children into dangerous situations. It allows for predators to take advantage of “court-rulings” and to gain power over [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Put my child and myself in danger, no help or protection, gave my child to the abuser. Left me broken, shattered, and facing criminal charges based on made up stories.

— HOLLY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My ex was convicted of second degree sexual assault of a child. My daughter was the victim. He threatened to kills us. I was granted a 10 year DVPO and he was sentenced to 4 years in prison, 6 years extended supervision, and is a lifelong registered sex offender. My two young [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has taken me from being a daily mother to allowing the father to push me out of my kid's lives entirely.

— SAMANTHA

I have watched my children deteriorate physically and psychologically. I have experienced the death of hope, the loss of the mother i wanted to be, the life I worked for stolen, the relationship I had with my children sabotaged.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed our relationship

— AMBER

every negative thing you could think about. and all for revenge.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They stole my 3 daughters from their mother, and trafficked them right into the arms of their pedophile father. They stole the ability for them to continue to be safe and heal, also to get help for the unimaginable abuse they each experienced.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Removed my daughter at birth because I had to prove I was the father thru a court ordered paternity test. In order to get custody of my daughter CPS and the judge decided I had to move to my father's an hour away from the apartment I shared with child's mother. I was forced to [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has broken my child because they believe 50/50 is what is just for the parents but refuse to acknowledge the ramifications of what that does to the child. The system is failing children and forcing them to be in situations their parent left. I have cared for my [...]

— AMANDA

Loss of time and memories!

— AMANDA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system has put my son in the custody of a documented physically and emotional abusive parent with no supervision or monitoring. The system tore my sons mother from his life, the only constant and safe parenting he had known since birth 2013. The system im referring to here [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

25 Wisconsin parents submitted ranked quotes. 25 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/wi.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Wisconsin report comes from Wisconsin respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Wisconsin — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 36 Wisconsin families reporting here are not the universe of Wisconsin families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics (email + name + submission date) are applied before aggregation. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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